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‘Misrecognition of the Limits’: Bourdieu’s Religious Capital and Social Transformation

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Figure 1

Figure 1: Figure 1

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"Misrecognition of the Limits": Bourdieu's *Religious Capital* and Social Transformation

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Political process models attempt to address the interaction between a social movement and the larger social environment, and treat society as a complex system of power relations through which a group may be denied or granted access to power. With the political process model, social movements are explained in terms of broad economic, demographic, and political processes that determine not only the context of a social movement, but how a movement develops or dissipates. Expanding this model, recent works in the study of social movements and social transformation have presented analyses that not only address the structural forces contributing to social movements, but include an analysis of their cultural and symbolic elements as well. However, political process theories do not explain many aspects of those social movements that occur *within* institutions. Concepts drawn from the work of Pierre Bourdieu can contribute to an increased understanding of the dynamics of social movements occurring within institutions, especially those organized around or emerging from religious interest. In the following paragraphs I examine various political process theories, discuss Bourdieu's concepts of *habitus*, *field*, *symbolic power*, and *religious capital*, and consider the case of a social movement within an institution: the women's ordination movement in the Catholic Church.

Introduction

Social Movements As Political Process

From The Work Of Bourdieu

*Habitus**Field**Symbolic Power**Cultural Capital*

The Ordination of Women

Conclusion and Continuance

Figure 1. Political process model.

Figure 2. Challenge within a field.

Figure 2

Figure 2: Figure 2

As to social transformation, whether occurring as a field challenge between orthodoxy and heresy, or through challenges mounted by social movements against institutions, it seems culture is an important factor in the success of a movement. All social relations are supported by a system of shared understandings, and these understandings are shaped by code as both objectified culture and practiced culture. The success of a social movement, then, may depend on how well cultural biases are reshaped, and to what extent misrecognition is recognized.

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